

Scotland at War - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Scotland at War

Here is a puzzle worth carrying through your Edinburgh week. Scotland sits about as far from the trenches of Flanders and the beaches of Normandy as anywhere in Britain. No battle of either world war was fought on Scottish soil. And yet, twice in thirty years, this quiet northern country found itself at the very center of the fight.

The reason is on the map. Scotland faces Germany across the North Sea, and its coast is slit with deep, sheltered firths, natural harbors big enough to hide a navy. So the Royal Navy came north. The Grand Fleet, the most powerful force afloat, spent the First World War in Scottish anchorages, at Scapa Flow in Orkney and here in the Firth of Forth, watching the sea lanes to Germany. Where the fleet went, the war followed. The first German air raid on Britain in the Second World War happened over the Forth, within sight of Edinburgh's rooftops. The entire German High Seas Fleet steamed into this same firth to surrender in nineteen eighteen. Radar, the invention that saved Britain in nineteen forty, was fathered by a Scot. Commandos and secret agents learned their trade in the Highland glens, and the price of it all is written in a shrine at the top of Edinburgh Castle that holds the names of the Scottish dead.

The traces are all around you this week. On day ten your boat crosses the exact water where Spitfires fought the first air battle and where the German fleet gave itself up. From Arthur's Seat you can see the whole theatre laid out below. Even the train south passes concrete defences still crouched on the beaches. This is the story of how a small country on the edge of Europe became the anchor of two world wars.

The First Raid: Spitfires Over the Forth

The Second World War's air battle over Britain began here, six weeks into the war and ten months before the Battle of Britain. On the sixteenth of October, nineteen thirty-nine, twelve Junkers Ju eighty-eight bombers of the Luftwaffe's Kampfgeschwader thirty crossed the North Sea to attack Royal Navy warships near the Forth Bridge and the Rosyth dockyard. Their leader was Hauptmann Helmut Pohle, and by his own later account his orders had a strange scruple to them: ships in dock were off limits, because bombs falling on a dockyard might kill civilians, and in October nineteen thirty-nine both sides were still pretending this would be a tidy war. The battlecruiser Hood, the biggest prize in the firth, was safely inside the dock, so the bombers went for the cruisers Southampton and Edinburgh and the destroyer Mohawk, lying in the open water your boat crosses on day ten.

No air raid siren sounded. The warning system simply failed, and so Edinburgh got its first air battle as a public spectacle. People stood in Princes Street and on the Fife shore watching aircraft wheel and dive over the bridge, many assuming it was an exercise, while golfers played on and spent machine-gun rounds pattered onto rooftops. Up from their airfields came the Spitfires of two auxiliary squadrons, six-oh-two, City of Glasgow, and six-oh-three, City of Edinburgh, weekend flyers, lawyers and farmers and businessmen, defending their own home towns. They shot two of the bombers into the sea. Fighter Command credited the first to Flight Lieutenant Pat Gifford of six-oh-three, a solicitor in civilian life, and these are counted as the first German aircraft destroyed over Britain in the Second World War. Pohle

himself was pulled from the water off Crail, the only survivor of his crew, and is often described as the war's first German prisoner taken in Britain. The raid was no comedy for the navy, though. Sixteen sailors died and forty-four were wounded, most aboard Mohawk, whose captain, Commander Richard Jolly, was mortally wounded yet refused to leave his bridge, brought his ship safely in, and died hours later. Twelve days after that, a Heinkel came down on a hillside at Humble in East Lothian, the first German aircraft brought down on British soil, and the auxiliaries had made their point. The Luftwaffe never got a free run at the Forth.

Edinburgh had actually been bombed from the air once before, and that story is stranger still. On the night of the second of April, nineteen sixteen, the Zeppelin L-fourteen droned over the blacked-out city, drawn by the lights of Leith after failing to find Rosyth and the bridge. For over an hour it wandered above Edinburgh dropping some forty-four bombs on a city with essentially no defence. A whisky warehouse in Leith went up in flames, a bomb killed six people in Marshall Street, and another exploded in the Grassmarket outside the White Hart Inn, directly below the castle. Thirteen or fourteen people died that night, depending which count you follow. Look down at the pavement by the White Hart when you're in the Grassmarket. There's a flagstone marking where the bomb fell, one small scar from the night the First World War reached Edinburgh's Old Town.

Operation ZZ and the Great Scuttling

The First World War at sea ended in the Firth of Forth, in the most extraordinary naval pageant ever staged. Ten days after the Armistice, on the twenty-first of November, nineteen eighteen, the German High Seas Fleet, nine battleships, five battlecruisers, seven light cruisers and fifty destroyers, steamed across the North Sea to give itself up. The Royal Navy called the plan Operation ZZ, and it took no chances. Before dawn the Grand Fleet put to sea, around one hundred and ninety Allied warships, British squadrons joined by American battleships and French ships, and formed two enormous parallel columns miles apart. The light cruiser Cardiff led the German line into the gap between them, and the columns then turned inward and escorted their old enemy into the firth, guns unloaded by agreement on the German side, but every Allied crew at action stations in case of a last act of defiance. There was none. That afternoon Admiral Beatty made the signal the fleet had waited four years for: the German flag is to be hauled down at sunset today, and is not to be hoisted again without permission. Ships' companies cheered him from end to end of the anchorage. Some of the older officers found it hard to watch. A fleet built to fight the greatest sea battle in history had ended without one, swinging at anchor off Inchcolm.

The Germans were moved north to Scapa Flow in Orkney, and there they sat for seven months, skeleton crews aboard rusting ships, while the politicians argued at Versailles over who would get them. Their commander, Rear Admiral Ludwig von Reuter, decided nobody would. On the twenty-first of June, nineteen nineteen, with the British guard squadron conveniently away on exercise, he hoisted a prearranged signal and every German crew opened the seacocks. Over the next five hours fifty-two of the seventy-four interned ships went to the bottom, the greatest single day's loss of shipping in history, battleships rolling over with steam roaring from their vents. By strange chance a boatload of Orkney schoolchildren on a sightseeing trip sailed right through it, and watched dreadnoughts capsize around them. Nine German sailors were shot in the confusion, often called the last dead of the First World War. Most of the wrecks were later raised for scrap, but seven still lie on the seabed, and divers travel from around the world to swim over them.

Scapa Flow's second war began with tragedy. On the night of the fourteenth of October, nineteen thirty-nine, two days before the Forth raid you've just heard about, the German submarine U-forty-seven, commanded by Guenther Prien, threaded through the blockships of a supposedly impassable channel and torpedoed the battleship Royal Oak at her anchorage. She rolled over in minutes. Eight hundred and thirty-five men and boys died, and boys is the accurate word, for the crew included over one hundred and sixty rated boy sailors between fourteen and eighteen, most of whom were lost. Churchill ordered the

eastern channels sealed for good, and the great concrete causeways built to do it, the Churchill Barriers, still carry Orkney's roads today. The labor came largely from Italian prisoners of war, and they left behind the war's most unexpected monument. Given two Nissen huts and whatever scrap they could find, prisoner Domenico Chiocchetti and his comrades built a complete Italian chapel, with a painted vault, a wrought-iron screen made from salvage, and concrete dressed up as carved stone. Chiocchetti stayed on after his fellow prisoners went home, to finish the sanctuary. The Italian Chapel is lovingly preserved, and it may be the gentlest thing either world war left behind in Scotland.

The Names, the City, and the Iolaire

You've stood, or you will stand, in the Scottish National War Memorial at the top of the castle, so let's talk about what those rolls of honour actually count, because the numbers are argued over to this day. The rolls hold roughly one hundred and forty-seven thousand names from the First World War. Historians point out that the figure includes non-Scots who served in Scottish regiments and some double counting, and the Oxford war historian Hew Strachan has argued the true Scottish death toll is probably nearer one hundred thousand, while others insist Scotland's losses were proportionally far heavier than the rest of Britain's. The honest answer is a range, somewhere between one hundred thousand and one hundred and fifty thousand dead from a country of under five million people. Whichever figure you take, the loss reached into every street, and once you start looking, Edinburgh is quietly covered in the marks of it. On the Royal Mile outside the City Chambers sits the Stone of Remembrance, where the city lays its wreaths each November. At Haymarket, west of Princes Street, a clock tower in the middle of the junction is the memorial to the Heart of Midlothian footballers who enlisted together in nineteen fourteen. Almost every kirk, school, bank and railway station you pass has its bronze plaque of names. The city never built one great monument because it built hundreds of small ones.

The Second World War here was lived rather than fought. Edinburgh was bombed only lightly, nothing like Clydebanks ordeal in the west, but the routines were the same as London's: the blackout, gas masks carried to school, Anderson shelters dug into back gardens, and thousands of children evacuated to the Borders and the Highlands with labels on their coats. Rationing bit deep and lasted absurdly long. Sweets stayed on the ration until nineteen fifty-three, eight years after the war ended, which means every Scot of a certain age remembers exactly where they were the week sweets came off.

And then there is the story Scotland itself could barely speak of for fifty years. In the first hours of New Year's Day, nineteen nineteen, weeks after the Armistice, the naval yacht Iolaire was carrying sailors home to the Isle of Lewis, men who had survived the whole war and were coming back for the first peacetime New Year. In darkness and heavy seas she struck rocks called the Beasts of Holm at the mouth of Stornoway harbour, so close to home that men drowned within sight of the harbour lights, some within sight of their own villages. Two hundred and one of the two hundred and eighty aboard died. One man, John Finlay Macleod of Ness, swam ashore with a line, and along the rope he held taut in the surf, dozens of men hauled themselves to safety. Nearly every family on Lewis lost someone or knew someone lost, after four years in which the island had already given more than most. The grief was so total that survivors and families simply stopped speaking of it, and the Iolaire went almost unmentioned for two generations. Only around the centenary in twenty nineteen did Scotland fully take the story back into memory. It may be the hardest single blow any British community took from the Great War, and it fell after the guns had stopped.

The Secret Highlands

While the cities blacked out and the firths filled with warships, the emptiest parts of Scotland were given the strangest jobs of the war. In nineteen forty-two the army took over Achnacarry Castle, seat of Cameron of Lochiel in Lochaber, and turned its grounds into the Commando Basic Training Centre,

the toughest school in the British forces. Over twenty-five thousand men passed through it by the war's end, British commandos plus French, Dutch, Norwegian, Polish and American volunteers, and the course was deliberately brutal: speed marches through the hills with full kit, river crossings in winter, assault landings on the loch practised with live ammunition fired over the boats. It's often called the birthplace of modern special forces training, and the idea that elite soldiers should be forged somewhere cold, wet and mountainous has never really gone away. On the road north at Spean Bridge, on a hillside every recruit marched past from the railway station, the Commando Memorial now looks out over the training ground, three bronze soldiers gazing toward Ben Nevis. It's one of Scotland's most visited monuments, and one of its most moving.

The secret agents had their own hidden Scotland. The Special Operations Executive, Churchill's sabotage service, ran paramilitary schools in requisitioned shooting lodges around Arisaig on the west coast, where agents bound for occupied Europe learned demolition, silent killing and survival. And in the Cairngorms, near Aviemore, three lodges collectively known as Station Twenty-six housed the Norwegians of Kompani Linge, chosen precisely because the terrain matched home, mountains, high passes and deep winter snow. The men who trained there pulled off what many rate the single finest sabotage operation of the war. In February nineteen forty-three, a small team of Norwegian skiers who had prepared in Scotland dropped onto a frozen plateau, climbed down and up a gorge the Germans considered impassable, broke into the heavily guarded Vemork plant in Telemark, and blew up the equipment producing heavy water for Germany's atomic research, then skied away. Not one shot was fired, not one saboteur was lost, and the German nuclear programme never recovered its footing.

And then there's the night Scotland's war turned surreal. On the tenth of May, nineteen forty-one, a lone Messerschmitt crossed the Scottish coast at dusk, and out of it, when the fuel ran low, parachuted Rudolf Hess, Deputy Fuehrer of Nazi Germany, third man in the Reich. He had flown solo from Augsburg on a self-appointed mission to negotiate peace, aiming for the estate of the Duke of Hamilton, whom he believed, on almost no evidence, would broker a deal. He bailed out over the village of Eaglesham south of Glasgow, broke his ankle landing in a field, and was found by David McLean, the ploughman at Floors Farm, who marched him to the farmhouse cottage and sat him by the fire while the family offered the bewildered Deputy Fuehrer a cup of tea. The story goes that McLean confronted him armed with a pitchfork, a detail Scotland has never wanted to fact-check too hard. Hitler declared Hess insane. Churchill, told of the news at the cinema, reportedly finished watching the Marx Brothers first. Hess spent the rest of his life in prison, and historians still argue about what exactly he thought he was doing. The field at Eaglesham is still just a field, which somehow makes the story better.

What Scotland Built and What It Cost

In both wars Scotland was as much workshop as fortress, and nowhere more than along the Clyde. Clydebuilt had been a worldwide byword for quality since Victorian times, and in wartime the river's yards turned out warships at a rate the enemy could only envy. That's exactly why the Luftwaffe came for it. On the nights of the thirteenth and fourteenth of March, nineteen forty-one, over four hundred bombers attacked Clydebank, the shipbuilding town at John Brown's yard where the great liners had been launched. It was Scotland's worst bombing of the war. The official count was five hundred and twenty-eight dead in Clydebank alone, with the toll across wider Clydeside put well above a thousand, and the town was effectively destroyed: of roughly twelve thousand houses, only a handful came through undamaged, and some thirty-five thousand people were left homeless out of a population of about fifty thousand. Yet the yards themselves recovered fast, and the workers came back, many walking in daily from the rest centres they'd been scattered to. Clydebank kept building ships to the end of the war, which was its own kind of defiance.

Much of that workforce, in both wars, was women. In the First World War the largest factory on earth ran along the border at Gretna, nine miles of cordite works where thirty thousand workers, twelve thousand of

them women, kneaded gun-cotton and nitroglycerine into shell propellant with their bare hands. Arthur Conan Doyle visited and named the explosive paste the devil's porridge, and the wages and independence those munitions girls earned helped push the vote for women over the line.

Scotland's greatest single contribution, though, may have been invisible. Robert Watson-Watt, a radio scientist from Brechin in Angus, and by family tradition a descendant of the engineer James Watt, proved in February nineteen thirty-five that an aircraft could be detected by bouncing radio waves off it. From that experiment grew Chain Home, the radar network that told Fighter Command where the Luftwaffe was in nineteen forty, and without which the Battle of Britain is probably lost. There's a postscript Scots love. Years later in Canada, Watson-Watt was pulled over for speeding, caught by a radar gun, and the story goes he told the officer that if he'd known what they'd do with it, he'd never have invented it. He even wrote a rueful poem about being the victim of his own creation.

The war's geography still shows if you know where to look. Atlantic convoys marshalled in the Clyde, and from nineteen forty-two the Arctic convoys to Russia assembled in Loch Ewe, a remote sea loch in the far northwest where up to ninety-five ships at a time lay at anchor before the terrible run to Murmansk. Nearly five hundred merchant ships sailed from that one quiet loch. And all around the coast, the defences of nineteen forty were simply left where they stood: pillboxes in the dunes, rows of concrete anti-tank cubes marching along beaches, airfields gone back to farmland. On day thirteen, as your train south hugs the East Lothian and Berwickshire coast, watch the beaches below the line. Those grey concrete blocks half-buried in the sand were put there to stop German tanks, and Scotland never bothered to tidy them away. The wars ended. The stone, as usual in Scotland, stayed.